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THA 341: Community Theatre for Development - TfD in Practice

Make theatre with a community, not about one

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 300L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Theatre for Development is participatory, research-led and ethically demanding. This pack covers the TfD cycle, key theorists from Boal and Freire to Abah and Etherton, participatory research methods, ethics and consent, and how to document a project honestly rather than claiming impact you did not measure.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the TfD cycle from entry to evaluation.
- Apply participatory methods to identify a community's priority issue.
- Design a drama process that invites community participation and ownership.
- Evaluate and document a project with honest evidence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What TfD is and is not

Development theatre is not a health message delivered with drums.

- Community members are participants and co-authors, not an audience to be instructed.
- The issue must emerge from dialogue with the community, not from the facilitator's assumptions.
- Aesthetics matter; a clumsy play patronises its audience and loses attention.
- Facilitators hold power and must manage it deliberately.
- Sustainability depends on local ownership, not donor enthusiasm.
- Documentation and evaluation are part of the work, not an afterthought.

The TfD cycle

A repeatable sequence keeps the work honest.

1. Entry and rapport building with community leaders and groups.
2. Participatory research: listening, mapping, ranking problems with the community.
3. Analysis and scenario building with local participants.
4. Workshop, improvisation and rehearsal.
5. Performance or intervention with audience participation.
6. Reflection, follow-up and evaluation with the community.

> **Boal's spect-actor**
> Forum theatre invites spectators to intervene in the action. Learn the technique properly rather than asking the audience for 'questions' at the end.

Ethics and honest evaluation

Community work carries obligations.

- Informed consent for participation, filming and photographs.
- Anonymity and confidentiality where individuals are vulnerable.
- Avoid extracting stories for assessment and disappearing.
- Do not claim behaviour change without evidence.
- Record attendance, contributions and follow-up actions.
- Share findings and the final documentation with the community.

Theatre for development is not theatre about development

The defining difference is authorship. In conventional theatre a writer produces a script and a community receives it. In theatre for development the community identifies the problem, contributes the material, tests the solutions in performance, and decides what happens afterwards. The outsider is a facilitator, not an author, and the measure of success is what changes after the performance, not how good the performance was.

This has consequences for every stage. Research is done with the community, in its language, at times and places it chooses. The drama is built from its own stories and idioms rather than imported formats. The performance is usually followed by a facilitated discussion in which the audience interrogates the action and proposes alternatives - and may join the scene to try them.

Because the aim is change, TfD projects fail when they are evaluated only as art. The useful evaluation asks: who participated, what did they learn, what did they decide, and what did they do next? A brilliant performance that leaves no decision behind has not completed the work.